Crusader Kingdoms — Game Design Document

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Working title — rename anytime.

Vision

A real-time medieval kingdom builder for phones: found a tiny realm anywhere on a real map of Europe and the Near East, grow it into an empire, and keep it alive through war, faith, diplomacy and family politics. Think Bannerlord's living world plus Total War: Shogun's battlefield command, in a cartoon stick-figure style on aged parchment.

Pillars

- **A living world.** Every AI kingdom grows, schemes, allies and dies on its own clock, whether or not you are watching.
- **Rule, don't just fight.** Food, faith, taxes and noble loyalty matter as much as armies. A bad ruler gets overthrown.
- **Command like a general.** Battles are won with terrain, timing and flanks, not just bigger numbers.
- **Crusades as the big set piece.** Faith-driven campaigns that pull many kingdoms into one war.
- **Your dynasty is your life bar.** If your bloodline ends, the game ends.

Art style: Chunky stick-figure soldiers with bucket helms and tabards, painted onto a sepia parchment world with ornate borders, banners and heraldry. Original designs, inspired by (not copied from) the reference ad.

Audience: Personal project for now; built to be playable by anyone who likes strategy games.

Look & feel

Two views, two moods: a strategic war-room map for the big picture, and a bright, busy cartoon battlefield when armies clash.

Campaign map (the overview) — reference: Supremacy 1914's map.

- Real geography with rivers, lakes, coastlines and mountain shading, viewed straight down.
- Each realm's territory is a solid color fill with soft borders; realm names written across their land in bold serif caps, scaling with realm size.
- Small realms in muted earth tones; big empires get stronger colors so power is readable at a glance.
- **Settlements are visible on the map:** castles (stone keep icon), towns (cluster of roofs), villages (a few huts), ports (dock + boat), monasteries/churches (spire). Icon size grows with settlement level; walls appear when built.
- **Armies are tokens:** a small banner/shield in the realm's heraldry with a troop count; they walk along roads and rivers. Clashes show smoke puffs; sieges show a ring of tents around the town.
- Battle markers, trade-route lines, and crusade arrows overlay the map.
- Zooming out shows only realms and big cities; zooming in reveals villages, roads and individual armies.

Battles & sieges — reference: Nightfall: Kingdom Frontier's siege view.

- Top-down, slightly angled cartoon battlefield in bright colors: green fields, round trees, blue lakes, dirt roads.
- Huge numbers of tiny chunky soldiers (hundreds per side), color-coded by side, each with a readable silhouette: spearmen, swordsmen, archers, knights on horses, siege engines.
- Defenders sit behind wooden palisades or stone walls with gates and archer towers; arrows arc visibly across the field.
- The town inside the walls is real terrain: houses, windmill, farms, a keep. Defenders can fall back street by street.
- Effects: arrow volleys, dust from charges, fire on burning buildings, smoke from trebuchet hits.
- Our soldiers keep the crusader identity: bucket helms, tabards with crosses or faction heraldry, shields and banners. Original designs, inspired by these references, not copied.

World & setting

The map is real geography (Iberia to the Caspian, Scandinavia to Egypt), split into roughly 300–400 provinces. The year is invented (Year 1 of a fictional calendar), so history is a sandbox, not a script.

- **Many small realms at start.** About 80–120 counties and petty kingdoms. Some carry real names (France, Hungary, Castile, Kyiv), most are invented. All start at 1–3 provinces.
- **Nothing is destined.** France may never form. A made-up duchy can swallow it after one bad AI decision.
- **Pick your spawn.** On a new game you tap any unclaimed province (or take over a starting realm). Example goal: forge a Slovak kingdom from the Carpathians, with a rising Hungary as the natural rival.
- **Terrain on the map:** plains, forest, hills, mountains, marsh, desert, rivers, coast. Terrain sets movement speed, food, defense and which battle map you fight on.
- **Settlements:** each province has one main town or castle plus villages. Ports on coasts, fortresses at chokepoints.
- **Cultures:** Latin, Frankish, Germanic, Slavic, Magyar, Norse, Greek, Arab, Turkic, Berber and others. Culture shapes unit rosters, names and building looks.

Core loop & real-time simulation

Time runs continuously on the campaign map, like Bannerlord, and you can pause, play at 1x, 2x or 4x. One in-game day passes every few seconds at 1x. The economy ticks daily; seasons change every 90 days.

The player's loop

1. Grow: collect food, gold, wood, stone and iron; construct buildings; grow population.
2. Recruit: turn people into troops, appoint generals, form armies.
3. Expand: march armies, siege towns, fight field battles, take provinces.
4. Rule: keep nobles loyal, people fed and the church happy; set taxes.
5. Deal: ally, trade, marry, threaten, betray.
6. React: rebellions, plagues, coups, crusade calls and AI wars keep interrupting the plan.

AI kingdoms run the same rules as you: they build, recruit, declare wars, sign treaties and collapse. Each AI ruler has traits (greedy, pious, cautious, ambitious, cruel) that bend their choices. A world news feed reports big events ("The Duchy of Carinthia has fallen to

Hungary").

Seamless world & command

The whole game is one continuous world and one camera, like No Man's Sky going from space to a planet: no loading screens and no separate battle mode. You zoom smoothly from the map of Europe down to a single soldier swinging a sword, and everything keeps running while you do.

Zoom levels (one continuous pinch):

Zoom	What you see	What you do
Continent	Realms as colored territories, big cities, army banners	Grand strategy, diplomacy, crusades
Region	Provinces, roads, rivers, towns, villages, armies marching	Move armies, give generals orders
Battlefield	Terrain up close: hills, forests, bridges; regiments as blocks with counts	Command regiments: flank, hold, ambush
Close-up	Individual stick-figure soldiers fighting, falling, routing; town workers at work	Watch, issue regiment orders, enjoy

Battles happen where armies meet, on the real terrain. If two armies clash at the Váh bridge, the fight is on that bridge, in that province, and the map around it keeps moving. Another battle can be raging two provinces away at the same time.

You are the king; generals do the fighting. You give orders on the map and your generals carry them out on their own until you step in:

- **Take** a town, castle, bridge or province (siege or assault).
- **Hold** a place: dig in, build stakes, defend the river crossing.
- **Raid** enemy villages and supply lines.
- **Intercept** an enemy army, or **Shadow** it without fighting.
- **Retreat** to a castle, or **Join** another army.
- Stance per order: cautious, balanced, aggressive (e.g. "hold at all costs" vs "fall back if losing").

Generals use their own skills and traits to fight the battle: a cautious general holds the bridge, a reckless one charges across it. Messengers report back ("Lord Kálmán holds the bridge, 41 enemy dead"). At any moment you can zoom in and take direct control of a battle, then zoom out and hand it back.

How this is built (simulation level of detail):

- Far away or off screen, battles run as a fast numbers simulation: regiments, terrain modifiers, morale, losses.
- When you zoom in, the same battle is drawn as individual soldiers whose fighting matches those numbers. Zoom out and it goes back to numbers, with no reset.
- The same applies to towns: workers and carts appear only when you zoom close; otherwise the town is just its production numbers.
- This is what keeps a whole continent of wars running on a phone.

City building & economy

Each town has building slots that grow with its level (village → town → city → capital). What you build decides what the province is good at.

Resource	Main source	Used for
Food	Farms, fishing, pastures	Feeding people and armies; growth
Gold	Taxes, markets, trade routes, loot	Upkeep, buildings, bribes, mercenaries
Wood	Lumber camps (forests)	Buildings, siege engines, ships
Stone	Quarries (hills, mountains)	Walls, castles, churches
Iron	Mines	Weapons and armor for better troops
Faith	Churches, monasteries, mosques	Crusades, legitimacy, calming unrest

Building lines: farms, markets, barracks, stables, archery range, blacksmith, walls (wood → stone → castle), church line, roads, port, granary, tavern (happiness, spies).

Population: each province has peasants, burghers, clergy and nobles. Peasants farm and fill levies; burghers pay taxes; clergy produce faith; nobles lead troops and expect power.

Happiness goes down from high taxes, hunger, war weariness, wrong religion, and occupation. It goes up from food surplus, festivals, churches, victories and low taxes. Below a threshold: riots, then rebellion armies spawn.

Food & seasons: harvest comes in autumn; winter cuts food, slows armies and adds attrition. A bad harvest event can starve a realm that over-recruited.

Armies & tactical battles

Armies march on the campaign map, led by a general (you, an heir, or a noble). When two armies meet, you choose **Command** (fight it yourself) or **Auto-resolve** (instant result from strength, terrain, general skill and morale).

Unit types (culture-flavored): levy spearmen, men-at-arms, archers, crossbowmen, light cavalry, knights, horse archers, siege crews. Units have tiers unlocked by buildings and iron.

Battle screen — overhead, top-down view, like a general looking at a table map:

- The battlefield is generated from the province terrain: forests, hills, rivers, villages, walls.
- You command regiments, not individual soldiers: drag to move, set formation (line, wedge, square), set stance (hold, charge, skirmish).
- **Terrain matters:** forests hide units and slow cavalry; hills give archers range and defense; rivers and bridges create chokepoints; village buildings give cover and break charges.
- **Ambush and flank:** hide cavalry in trees, wait for the enemy to commit, then hit their side or rear for a big morale shock.
- **Morale decides battles:** units rout when flanked, outnumbered, tired or when the general falls. Routing units can rally.
- **Sieges:** blockade to starve, or build rams, ladders and trebuchets to assault walls.
- Mobile controls: tap to select, drag to move, two-finger pan and zoom, slow-motion button.

After battle: prisoners (ransom, release, execute — with honor/reputation effects), loot, veterancy for survivors, and the general may be wounded or killed.

Siege battles in detail:

- **Before the assault:** camp outside, starve the town, and build siege gear over days (ladders, rams, siege towers, trebuchets, later cannons).

- **Defenses scale with buildings:** wooden palisade → stone walls → castle with towers and a moat. Archer towers fire on their own; gates must be rammed or opened by spies.
- **Assault:** pick a breach point, send rams at the gate, ladders at the walls, archers to suppress the towers, cavalry waiting to pour through.
- **Defending:** man the walls, hold the gate, sally out to burn siege engines, retreat to the keep if the walls fall.
- **Terrain still matters:** lakes and rivers protect sides of a town, forests hide a relief army, hills give trebuchets range.

Battles use the seamless camera (see Seamless world & command). Zoomed out, regiments are blocks with counts (reference: Last Fiefdom). Zoomed in, they open into individual stick-figure soldiers (references: Nightfall, Kingshot). Terrain counts in the numbers: a bridge limits how many can fight at once, a hill adds archer range, a ford slows troops, stakes stop cavalry, a forest hides units.

Diplomacy & trade

Every realm tracks an opinion of every other realm (−100 to +100), shaped by borders, religion, past wars, marriages, gifts, broken promises and ruler traits.

Actions: declare war, offer peace (with terms: land, gold, hostages), non-aggression pact, alliance, defensive pact, trade agreement, royal marriage, demand tribute, send gifts, insult, become a vassal or demand vassalage, call allies to war, join a crusade.

Trade: trade agreements open routes between markets. Routes carry goods (grain, wine, iron, silk, salt) and pay gold to both sides. Wars and pirates cut routes. Coastal ports unlock sea trade.

Treaties can break. AI rulers weigh honor against opportunity. A weak ally may be abandoned; a strong neighbor may betray a pact. Breaking treaties costs reputation with everyone.

Spies (later layer): taverns train spies to learn enemy armies, sabotage, incite rebellion, or plot assassinations.

Religion & crusades

Religions are the real ones of the period: Catholic, Orthodox, Sunni Islam, Shia Islam, Judaism (as communities inside realms), and Norse/Baltic/Slavic pagan faiths. Each province has a majority faith; each ruler has a personal faith.

Faith in cities: churches, cathedrals, monasteries and mosques produce Faith and happiness. Ruling provinces of another faith lowers happiness unless you build tolerance or convert them over time (missionaries, with unrest risk).

Religious authority: each faith has a head (the Pope, the Patriarch, a Caliph) run by the AI. Their opinion of you depends on piety, donations and obedience. Excommunication is possible.

Crusades — the big set piece, three ways in:

1. **Answer a call.** The religious head calls a crusade against a target region. You can send an army (led by a noble or heir), pay gold instead, or go yourself.
2. **Lend troops to another leader.** Your soldiers fight under an allied king; you share the glory and the loot.
3. **Launch your own.** With enough Faith and piety you request or declare a crusade, lead it, and use diplomacy to recruit other kings. They can send troops, come in person, or ignore you.

Crusade rewards: Faith, legitimacy, prestige, loot, relics (permanent bonuses), new land in the target region, and opinion boosts with co-religionists. Failure costs men, money and prestige. Counter-crusades (jihad, holy wars) work the same way for other faiths.

Crusade window: calls only become possible after the world matures (e.g. Year 20+) so you have time to grow first.

Dynasty, nobles & the never-ending world

Your dynasty: you play as the ruling family, not one man. The king ages, marries, has children and dies (battle, illness, old age, assassination). The heir takes over by succession law (eldest son, eldest child, elective, or chosen heir). Marriages seal alliances and can give claims on other thrones.

You lose when your ruler dies and no member of your dynasty can inherit, or a coup or rebellion places a rival family on your throne and you have no claimant left. Conquering every province is the technical win, but the world is built to keep going.

Nobles & loyalty: you grant provinces and army command to noble families. Each has loyalty, ambition and power. Disloyal, powerful nobles demand titles, refuse to send troops, form factions, and finally attempt a coup or civil war.

Coups & elections: rival families can scheme for the crown. Elective realms hold elections among great families when the ruler dies; you bribe, marry and threaten to win them.

Rebellions: peasant revolts (hunger, taxes), religious uprisings, noble revolts, and separatist provinces that want independence.

Random events: plague, bad harvest, bumper harvest, wandering mercenaries, a relic found, a traveling merchant, a comet (omens), a rival's insult, a famous knight asking to serve, a child prodigy heir.

Heroes & generals: named commanders level up with skills (tactics, siegecraft, logistics, leadership) and can be captured, ransomed or killed.

Tech

Engine: Godot 4 (free, open source). Exports to iOS and Android; you test on desktop during development. Language: GDScript.

What you need: a computer (Mac needed for the final iPhone build), Godot 4.3+ installed, and later Xcode or Android Studio for phone builds.

Architecture:

- `data/` — provinces, realms, religions, cultures, units, buildings as JSON, so content is easy to tweak.
- `sim/` — the simulation, separate from visuals: world clock, economy tick, AI decisions, diplomacy, events. Runs the same whether or not you're looking.
- `map/` — campaign map rendering: provinces colored by realm, armies as tokens, pan/zoom.
- `battle/` — battles drawn on the same map terrain, switching between numbers and individual soldiers by zoom (layer 3).
- `ui/` — mobile-first HUD: top resource bar, bottom action buttons, side panels.
- Save/load as JSON snapshots of the world state.

Map plan: layer 1 uses a simplified, hand-tuned province grid laid over a Europe outline; later we swap in accurate province shapes from public map data.

Build roadmap

Each layer ends with something playable before the next begins.

1. **Layer 1 — Living map.** Provinces on a Europe-shaped map, ~40 starting realms, pick your spawn, real-time clock with pause/speed, one seamless zoomable camera from continent to region, AI realms expanding and fighting each other via auto-resolve, world news feed. *Done when:* you can watch empires form and die in a 20-minute session.
2. **Layer 2 — Your realm.** Resources, buildings, population, taxes, happiness, recruiting armies, moving armies, sieges via auto-resolve, rebellions from hunger and tax.
3. **Layer 3 — Battles.** Zoom straight from the map into battles fought on the real map terrain (no separate battle scene), generals fighting on their own from your Take/Hold/Raid orders, regiments, formations, flanking, morale, ambush in forests, villages as cover, sieges with walls.
4. **Layer 4 — Diplomacy, religion, crusades.** Opinion system, treaties, trade routes, faiths in provinces, religious heads, crusade calls, launching your own crusade.
5. **Layer 5 — Dynasty & drama.** Aging, heirs, marriages, succession, nobles and loyalty, coups, elections, random events, heroes, lose conditions.
6. **Layer 6 — Polish & phone.** Final art pass in the parchment stick-figure style, sound, tutorial, iOS/Android builds.

Open questions

- [ ] Final game title
- [ ] Exact map borders (how far east and south)
- [ ] Naval battles: in or out?
- [ ] Should you be able to switch to playing a different family member or noble after a coup?